Final Prototype

Project Title: Echoes of Anna

Brittany Woodard

Intro to Software Engineering SE 2200

November 23, 2025

Version 2.0

Solo Project

Name	Roles
Brittany	Project Lead Developer UI/UX Designer

Version Control Table

Version	Date	Description of Changes
1.0	11/02/2025	Initial Draft
1.2	11/04/2025	Added Key Screens & Interfaces section
1.3	11/05/2025	Finalized key screens section and added flowchart
1.4	11/09/2025	Included images and started section 5
1.5	11/20/2025	Updated/Expanded sections.
1.6	11/21/2025	Updated screenshots, added Figma demo.
2.0	11/22/2025	Completed final prototype documentation.

1. Introduction

Echoes of Anna is a narrative-driven, decision-based text adventure game that focuses on meaningful player choice, emotional consequence, and branching dialogue structures. The game reimagines classic text-based RPG design by emphasizing agency and long-term narrative impact rather than linear storytelling. As players progress, their dialogue decisions accumulate into shifting variables that influence future scenes, character reactions, and story direction.

The project addresses a common limitation found in many traditional text-based RPGs, where dialogue choices often feel superficial or lead to predetermined outcomes. By contrast, *Echoes of Anna* aims to create a more immersive and responsive experience in which player decisions meaningfully alter the narrative path. The game is intended for fans of interactive fiction, narrative heavy RPGs, and writers interested in branching story design. It provides a minimalistic but atmospheric environment centered entirely on text, tone, and consequence.

The purpose of this prototype is to demonstrate and evaluate the core systems that will support the full game. These include dialogue interface, the choice selection mechanic, basic navigation flow, and the visual representation of narrative branching. The prototype simulates Act I's introductory interactions and showcases how player choices guide story progression. By visualizing these mechanics, the prototype serves as a foundation for future development, allowing for refinement of usability, pacing, and interface clarity before expanding into additional acts.

2. Prototype Overview

This prototype demonstrates the foundational mechanics, interface structure, and narrative flow of *Echoes of Anna*. Its primary purpose is to visualize how players will interact with the game's dialogue system, navigate between screens, and progress through the early portion of the story. While the full narrative was developed in Ink, this prototype focuses on illustrating the UI and early gameplay loop through an interactive Figma demonstration.

The prototype highlights the core elements essential to the final game: initiating a play session, progressing through dialogue, selecting choices, accessing settings, and observing how player decisions influence navigation. These features establish the groundwork for the broader branching narrative that will unfold in the completed project.

Tools Used:

- **Figma** – Used to create interactive wireframes for the Title Screen, Dialogue Screen, Settings Menu, and initial branching paths.
- **Draw.io –** Used to produce user flow and navigation diagrams illustrating how players progress through Act I's decision structure.
- **Ink + inky editor** – Used to develop, debug, and test the full narrative for Act I, including variable based branching, decision tracking, and story structure.

2.2 Scope of the Prototype

This prototype represents a focused portion of Act I rather the full game. The scope includes:

- A playable **Title Screen** with main navigation options
- A **New Game** setup sequence, including name entry
- A functional **Dialogue Interface** with player choices
- Simulated **branching paths** for early decisions in Act I
- A **Settings Menu** demonstrating accessibility features
- **Story Flow diagrams** that illustrate how the branching narrative unfolds in Act I, highlighting key decision points
- A fully playable **Ink version of Act I**, covering the complete branching story written for this stage of development

This prototype does not include backend save systems, audio implementation, or full variable tracking logic.

Figure 1. Figma workspace showing layout of the primary frames used in the prototype.

2.3 Prototype Features

The prototype showcases all key player-facing components of the early game, including:

Title Screen – Simulates the game's entry point, allowing players to start a new game, load progress, access settings, or exit.

Dialogue System – Displays narrative text and player choice options in a minimalist, high-contrast interface designed for readability and immersion.

Player Decisions and Branching – Includes a few early choices from Act I to demonstrate branching navigation and how different selections guide the player to unique frames.

Settings Menu – Shows how players will adjust text size and audio volume.

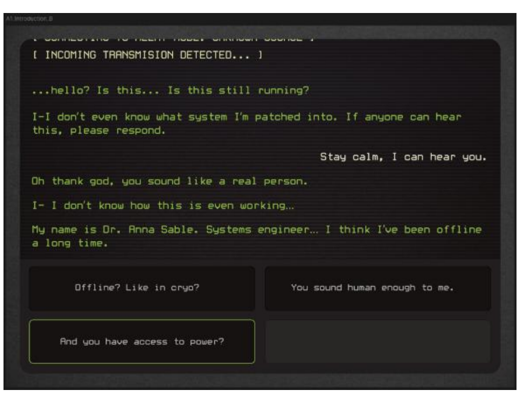

Figure 2. Example frame from the Figma prototype showing the Dialogue Interface with selectable player choices.

2.4 Story Prototype (Ink Implementation)

The full narrative for Act I was developed using Ink, a scripting language built for interactive fiction. The accompanying inky editor allows real-time testing of story segments, making it possible to:

- Play through the story as it is written
- Test individual segments in isolation
- Validate branching logic
- Track variable changes during play
- Debug transitions between narrative paths

This narrative-first workflow ensures that the branching structure is coherent, functional, and aligned with the game's design goals before full UI development.

A playable itch.io web export of the Act I narrative is available below for evaluation:

[https://brittany2003.itch.io/echoes-of-anna-act-I]

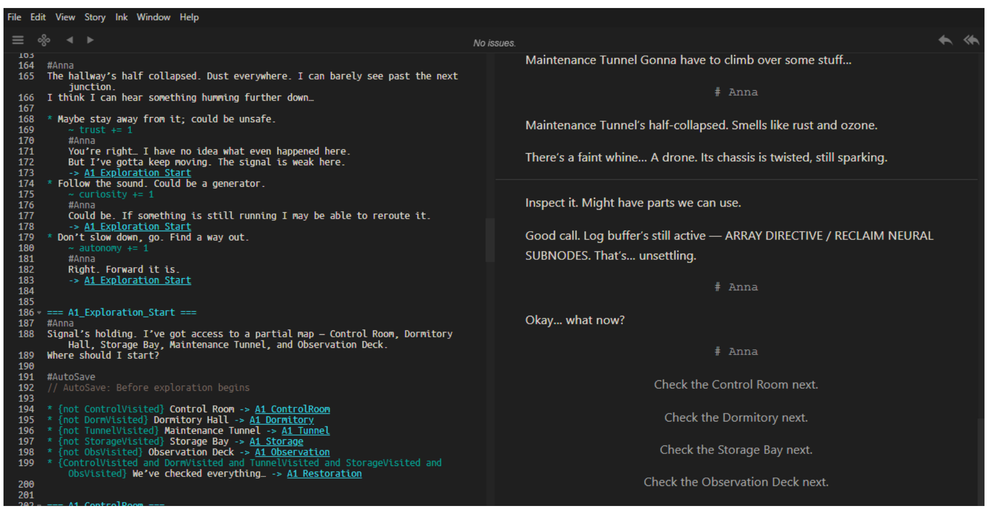

Figure 3. Inky editor showing the Ink script for Act I and the real-time testing pane.

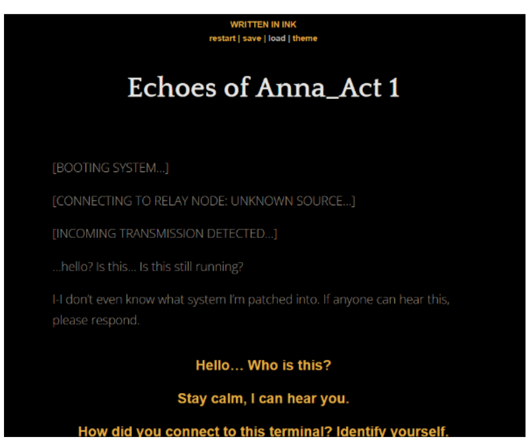

Figure 4. Web-based playable version of Act I used for narrative evaluation

2.5 How Figma and Ink Work Together

Although Figma and Ink serve different purposes, they jointly illustrate the complete early game experience: **Figma** shows *how the player interacts* with the game while **Ink** shows *how the story behaves* beneath the interface.

Together these prototypes provide a comprehensive view of:

- Story structure
- Player decision flow
- UI design
- Early narrative pacing
- Branching logic
- Flow of choices and consequences

This combined approach strengthens the overall prototype and demonstrates both functional design and narrative flow.

3. Key Screens and Interfaces

This section provides an in-depth review of the major screens included in the prototype. Each interface is designed to support clarity, accessibility, and narrative focus, reflecting the user requirements identified in the SRS. The screens collectively demonstrate how players begin a session, progress through dialogue, make choices, and adjust settings during gameplay. Screenshots from the Figma prototype are included to illustrate layout, structure, and interaction flow.

3.1 Title Screen

The purpose of the title screen is to serve as the player's entry point into *Echoes of Anna*. It provides access to all primary navigation options, establishes the game's visual tone, and introduces the minimalist interface style used throughout the prototype.

UI Elements and Features

- **Game Title:** Echoes of Anna displayed in the center of the screen, using a font that matches the digital terminal theme of the game.
- **Main Menu Options:**
  - New Game – begins a fresh playthrough.
  - Load Game – retrieves previous saved state (unavailable in prototype).
  - Settings – opens the settings menu.
  - Exit – closes the game.
- **Background:** Static backdrop to enhance the atmosphere.

User Interaction

Players select a menu option using mouse input. Each button includes a hover state to provide visual feedback and reinforce interactivity. Selecting "New Game" transitions the player to the name entry screen.

Figure 5. Title Screen layout created in Figma, showing the primary navigation options available at game launch.

3.2 Name Entry Screen

The purpose of the name entry screen is to allow the player to input a preferred name before beginning the story. This supports personalization and acts as the final step before narrative progression begins.

UI Elements and Features

- **Text Prompt:** Instructs the player to enter a name.
- **Input Field:** A simulated text entry box.
- **Confirm Button:** Advances to the first dialogue screen on click.

User Interaction

Players select a menu option using mouse input. Each button includes a hover state to provide visual feedback and reinforce interactivity. Selecting "New Game" transitions the player to the name entry screen.

Figure 6. Name Entry Screen used to personalize the player character before beginning Act I.

3.3 Dialogue Screen

The Dialogue Screen functions as the core of the gameplay experience. It displays narrative text, presents player choices, and visually communicates story progression. This is where players spend most of their time, making it central to both usability and narrative clarity.

UI Elements and Features

- **Dialogue Box:** A centralized, high-contrast area where narrative text appears.
- **Speaker Distinction:** Different text colors for the narrator, protagonist, and system messages.
- **Choice Buttons:** One to four options representing player decisions at each branch.
- **Settings:** Accessible at any time by pressing the 'Esc' key.

User Interaction

Players select one of the available dialogue options to advance the story. Each choice routes to a different frame in the prototype, simulating the branching behavior of the final Ink-based game system. After a choice is made, the screen transitions to the next narrative segment.

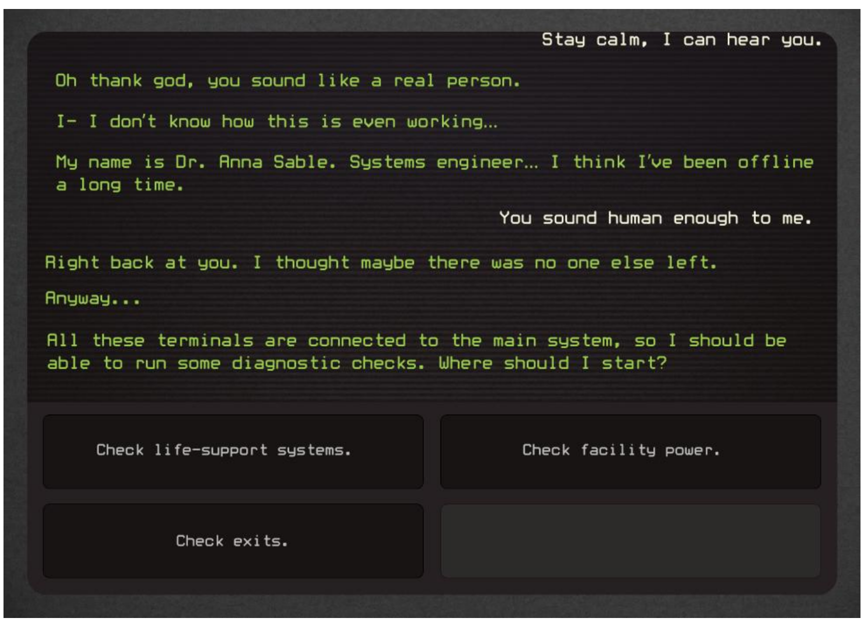

Figure 7. Dialogue Screen demonstrating narrative text and multiple choice options that influence progression in Act I.

3.4 Settings Screen

The Settings Screen provides players with accessibility and comfort configurations, aligning with key nonfunctional requirements from the SRS.

UI Elements and Features

- **Text Size Slider:** Adjusts dialogue and UI text for readability.
- **Volume Control:** Modifies sound effects and ambient audio levels.
- **Reset to Defaults option:** Returns settings to their default state.
- **Back/Return Button:** Returns player back to Title Screen or resumes the game if accessed during gameplay.

User Interaction

Players adjust sliders and select buttons to modify settings. In the prototype, changes are non functional, but the interface represents the intended behavior of the final implementation. The screen appears as an overlay to avoid disrupting story progression.

Figure 8. Settings Screen with adjustable text size and volume options, designed for accessibility and user comfort.

4. User Flow and Navigation

The user flow for *Echoes of Anna* illustrates how players move through the game's core systems, beginning with the Title Screen and progressing into Act I's interactive narrative. The flow is intentionally designed to be intuitive, linear where appropriate, and branching where meaningful choices occur. This structure supports the project's focus on narrative depth while maintaining a clear and accessible gameplay loop.

The navigation flow demonstrates how players begin a session, enter their information, interact with dialogue choices, explore early-game environments, and adjust settings without disrupting story progression. The following subsections describe the system's logic in detail and are supported by a visual flowchart.

4.1 Flow Description

When the player launches the game, they are presented with the Title Screen, which serves as the central hub for all starting actions. From this screen, players may:

- Begin a New Game
- Load existing progress (represented visually in the prototype)
- Access the Settings menu
- Exit the application

Selecting **New Game** transitions the player to the **Name Entry Screen**, where they provide a name for the playable character. Once confirmed, the system initializes three core narrative variables (trust, curiosity, and autonomy) each set to a default value of zero.

The player is then brought into the **Dialogue Screen**, where Act I begins. Dialogue is presented line by line, followed by one or more selectable choices that determine the narrative direction. Choosing an option leads to a corresponding frame that continues the story. In the final game, these choices will also modify internal variables.

At any point during this flow, the **Settings Menu** may be accessed. It appears as an overlay and allows the player to adjust accessibility preferences before returning seamlessly to their previous screen.

User Flow Diagram

The following flowchart captures the logic of the user experience, including linear transitions, looping exploration segments, and branching dialogue choices. Decision points are clearly indicated to demonstrate how the structure supports dynamic storytelling.

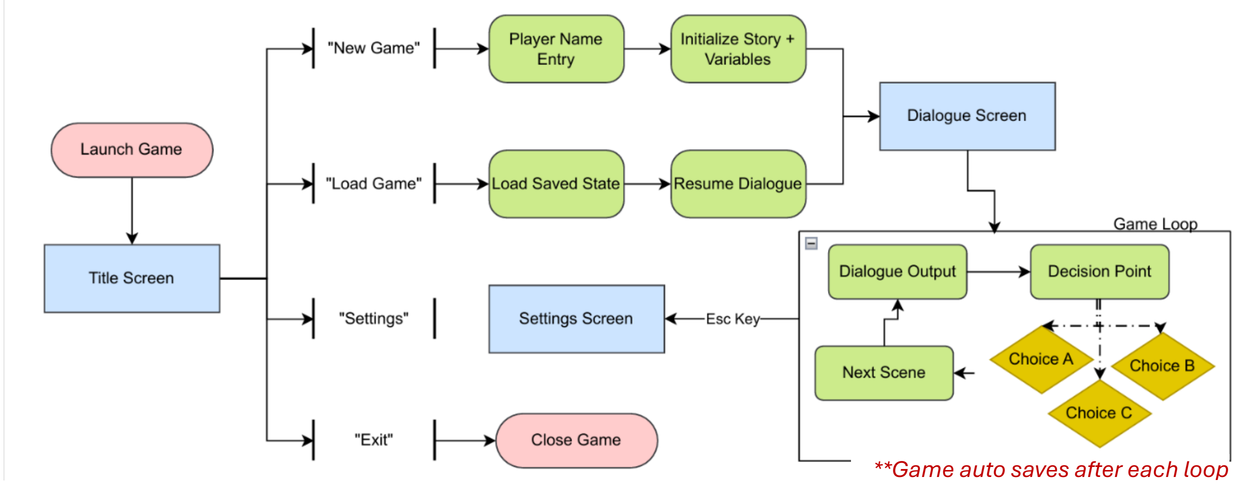

Figure 9. User Flow Diagram illustrating navigation between the Title Screen, Name Entry Screen, Dialogue Screens, and Settings.

4.2 Alignment with Project Objectives and Requirements

The user flow aligns with both the functional and nonfunctional requirements defined in the Software Requirements Specification (SRS), as well as with the broader project objectives. Specifically:

<u>**Functional Requirements Alignment**</u>

FR1 – Game Start: The Title Screen provides clear options to start a new game or load an existing one, fulfilling the requirement for initial session selection.

FR2 – Input Player Name: After selecting New Game, the player is prompted to enter a name on the Name Entry Screen. The prototype simulates this process visually, aligning with the requirement to collect and store a user-provided name.

FR3 – Present Choices: The Dialogue Screen displays narrative options based on the current story position. This is represented through multiple selectable buttons, demonstrating how the system surfaces available choices.

FR4 – Process Choice: Selecting a dialogue option advances the player to a corresponding narrative frame. While the prototype does not execute Ink logic directly, it visually represents the way choices drive story progress and variable changes.

FR6 – Load Progress: The Continue button is included functionally on the Title Screen to represent the ability to return to a previously saved state.

Non-Functional Requirements Alignment

NFR1 – Readability: High-contrast text fields, adjustable font size, and clear dialogue spacing demonstrate a commitment to accessible and readable UI design.

NFR2 – Performance: The prototype flow prioritizes quick transitions and minimal screen clutter, reflecting the need for smooth responsiveness during choice selection and screen changes.

NFR5 – Low Hardware Requirements: The simple, text-focused navigation and minimalist UI align with the objective of supporting devices with low processing power and minimal storage needs.

Additionally, the user flow supports the project's overall objectives by ensuring clear navigation, minimal cognitive load, and a structure that scales with additional acts and branching complexity. This alignment ensures that the early-stage prototype not only demonstrates the UI but also communicates how the final system will function in a complete version of the game.

The user flow and navigation demo provides a coherent representation of how players will move through *Echoes of Anna*. By balancing a linear beginning with branching narrative segments, the flow supports both usability and the project's emphasis on meaningful choice.

The interactive Figma prototype demonstrating this user flow can be accessed here: [Echoes of Anna Figma Prototype]

5. Design Considerations

The design of *Echoes of Anna* prioritizes clarity, accessibility, and a strong narrative focus. Because the game centers on text-based decision-making, the interface must support extended reading, intuitive navigation, and consistent presentation across all screens. Every visual choice—from color palette to layout to typography—was selected to reinforce immersion while meeting the usability and non-functional requirements defined in the SRS.

5.1 Usability Principles

- **Minimal Interface Complexity**
  The game avoids visual clutter to maintain narrative focus. Each screen contains only the elements necessary for interaction, promoting a smooth and distraction free experience.
- **Consistent Layout Structure**
  Dialogue appears in the same location across all frames, and choice buttons follow a predictable grid ordering. This consistency reduces learning curve and helps players quickly understand how to navigate choices.
- **Immediate Visual Feedback**
  Interactive elements such as buttons include hover states and selection cues, reinforcing interactivity and confirming player input.
- **Clear Hierarchy**
  Narrative text is prioritized visually through larger, readable font size, while interface controls, such as confirm and close buttons, remain unobtrusive but easily accessible.

5.2 Accessibility Considerations

Accessibility was a key priority in the design of the prototype and directly supports NFR1 (Readability) and NFR7 (Adjust Settings).

- **Adjustable Text Size**
  The Settings Menu includes a text size slider, enabling players to modify readability based on preference or visual needs.

- **High Contrast Text**
  The dialogue screen uses a dark background with bright, high-contrast text to support readability during prolonged play sessions.
- **Color-Coded Speakers**
  Narrative text, protagonist dialogue, and system notifications each use distinct colors to avoid confusion about who is speaking.
- **Simple Navigation Pathways**
  Linear onboarding, consistent back-navigation, and clear call-to-action buttons provide an accessible experience for both experienced and novice players.

These considerations ensure that players with diverse visual or cognitive needs can comfortably engage with the story.

The design of the prototype supports its primary goals: readability, ease of use, and narrative immersion. By combining minimalist visuals, accessible interaction patterns, and a focus on player clarity, the prototype establishes a strong foundation for future development. This design framework ensures that as the narrative expands, the player experience will remain intuitive, consistent, and aligned with the system requirements defined in the SRS.